



RESEARCH PROPOSAL

Brand Overview

Saxbys is a mission-driven café company that partners with universities to operate campus locations serving beverages (specialty coffee, matcha collection, teas, smoothies, energy drinks, and other café beverages) and grab-and-go food. The brand integrates an experiential learning platform into its cafés, where students manage daily operations in leadership roles while delivering hospitality services to the campus community.

Objective

The objective of this research is to understand how college students perceive Saxbys' student-run experiential café model, assess awareness and associations with its brand and educational mission on campus, and identify motivations and barriers to student interest in working at Saxbys.

- **Understand students' recognition and understanding of Saxbys' student-run experiential café model and its educational mission**
 - What are college students' understanding of the idea of a café run by and for students?
 - To what extent do students recognize Saxbys as a student-run or experiential learning café?
 - How do students interpret the purpose behind this model?
 - What does "experiential learning" mean to students in the context of a campus café?
 - What cues or signals make a student-run model noticeable in a campus café environment?
 - How do students expect the experience or atmosphere to differ from other campus cafés?
- **Understand student awareness, perceptions, and brand associations related to Saxbys as a campus brand**
 - How aware are students of Saxbys as a brand on campus?
 - What associations or perceptions do students hold about Saxbys?
 - What cues shape students' perception of Saxbys as a campus brand (location, design, messaging, word-of-mouth, pricing, partnerships, etc.)?
 - How do students perceive Saxbys' role within campus life?
- **Understand motivations and barriers influencing student interest in working at Saxbys**
 - What motivates students to consider working at a campus café like Saxbys?
 - How do students perceive the career or skill development value of working at Saxbys?
 - What expectations do students have about the workplace experience at a student-run café?
 - What concerns, barriers, or misconceptions discourage interest in working at Saxbys?

Target Audience

- **Demographics:** College students ages 18–24, primarily undergraduate students at Boston University; diverse backgrounds, including domestic and international students with limited disposable income.
- **Geographics:** Students living on or near Boston University's campus.
- **Psychographics:** Students who value authenticity, peer connection, and environments that feel comfortable and low-pressure. They are drawn to brands that reflect campus life and understand student needs, offering both functional convenience and a sense of belonging.
- **Behavioral:** Frequent campus café users whose purchases align with class schedules, study periods, and stress cycles. They rely on proximity, speed, and mobile ordering for convenience and are

willing to spend on small, affordable treats that enhance mood or focus. Their café choices are influenced by peer presence, routine habits, and social visibility on platforms such as Instagram and TikTok.

Research Plan

Primary Research

1. Online Survey

- **Objective:** To measure how students perceive Saxbys' student-run model and educational mission, understand it as a brand, and evaluate motivations and barriers to working at Saxbys.
- **Target Audience:** Boston University undergraduate students
- **Platform:** Qualtrics
- **Respondents:** 70-100
- **Length:**
 - i) Estimated time to complete survey: 5-7 minutes
 - ii) Anticipated number of questions: 15-18 questions
- **Sourcing methods:** Clubs/organizations, social media platforms like LinkedIn/Instagram/Facebook/BU Subreddit/Snapchat, QR code flyers at campus buildings, and personal peer networks.

Key Survey Topics

- Demographics:
 - Age
 - Year of study
 - University
 - On-campus vs. off-campus living
- Café Behavior:
 - Frequency of café visits per week
 - Typical visit times (day/afternoon/evening/night)
 - Average time spent at cafés
 - Do students prefer on-campus or off-campus cafés?
 - Primary reasons for visiting
- Perception of Student-Run Cafés:
 - What being "student-run" means to students
 - Recognition of Saxbys as an experiential learning café
 - Interpretation of the purpose behind a student-run model
 - Understanding of "experiential learning" within a café environment
 - Expectations of how a student-run café should differ from traditional campus cafés
 - Cues that signal a student-led environment
- Awareness & Perceptions of Saxbys:
 - Awareness and familiarity with Saxbys
 - Brand associations of Saxbys (student-driven, belonging, campus fit)
 - Perceived role in campus life
- Interest & Barriers of employment:
 - Interest in working at Saxbys
 - Motivations (skills, leadership, experience)
 - Barriers or concerns (time, pay, fit, awareness)

2. Focus Groups

- **Objective:** To explore how students interpret and emotionally respond to Saxbys' student-run experiential café model, how they perceive its brand within campus life, and what motivations or concerns shape interest in working at Saxbys.
- **Platform:** In-person (preferred) or Zoom
- **Number of groups:** 2 focus groups
- **Participants per group:** 5-7 students each (Total number = 10-14 approx.)
- **Duration of focus group:** 45-60 minutes
- **Sourcing methods:** Social media recruitment, class group chats, word-of-mouth, QR code signups.

Focus Group Topics

- Campus Café Preferences & Choice Drivers:
 - Students' typical campus café habits, preferences, and reasons for returning
 - Emotional and situational drivers of café choice (stress, routine, social needs)
 - What makes a café feel like "their spot" vs. interchangeable
 - Role of atmosphere, people, and familiarity in loyalty
 - Trade-offs between convenience, vibe, and product
- Student-Run Model Meaning:
 - Interpretations of "student-run," expectations, and cues that signal student leadership
 - Mental image of a student-run café experience
 - Signals that make student leadership visible or believable
 - Perceived purpose behind the student-run model
 - Reactions to peer-led vs. corporate-run environments
- Saxbys Brand Perception & Campus Role:
 - Perceptions of Saxbys, sense of student focus, and fit within campus life vs. other cafés
 - Associations linked to Saxbys (personality, vibe, community role)
 - Comparisons with other campus café options
 - Moments or touchpoints shaping current perceptions
- Employment Interest & Barriers:
 - Motivations, appeal factors, and concerns related to working at Saxbys
 - Drivers of interest (skills, resume value, personal goals)
 - Hesitations or misconceptions about the experience
 - Conditions that would increase likelihood of applying

Secondary Research

- **Competitive Analysis**
 - **Objective:** To examine how competing coffee brands build relevance and preference among college students on campus.
 - **Sources:** Brand websites and social channels; Google Reviews; Yelp.
 - **Competitors to Analyze**
 - Starbucks
 - Dunkin'
 - Pavement Coffeehouse
 - **Key Areas to Explore**
 - How competitors position themselves within campus life.
 - Messaging and visual strategies used to signal student relevance, belonging, or community.

- In-store and environmental cues that attract and retain college student traffic.
 - Social media tone, content themes, and engagement tactics appealing to college audiences.
 - Gaps where Saxbys' student-run model provides unique relevance not claimed by competitors.
- **Scope & Method**
 - Audit of brand websites and campus location experiences.
 - Comparative social media content analysis (Instagram, TikTok).
 - Review of promotional campaigns and seasonal activations.
- **Trend Study**
 - **Objective:** To identify evolving café behaviors and expectations among college students.
 - **Sources:** Mintel, GWI, Nielsen, Reddit, Pinterest Trends, Google Trends, TikTok Trends, Meltwater.
 - **Key Areas to Explore**
 - Emotional and situational drivers of campus coffee purchases.
 - Beverage preferences on campus.
 - “Small treat” and mood-based consumption during academic cycles.
 - Opportunities for Saxbys' student-run identity to align with emerging student values and behaviors.
 - **Scope & Method**
 - Review and synthesis of student behavior and café industry reports.
 - Analysis of campus foodservice and college lifestyle research.
 - Identification of trends with direct implications for Saxbys' campus relevance.

Results

Findings will be presented in a Google Slides presentation and include:

- Survey data visualizations (bar charts, pie charts, cross-tabs, ranking charts)
- Observations from focus groups
- Quotes, Audio Recordings, and Transcript from Focus Group
- Map of student perception on what makes a café feel student-centred and authentic
- Competitive analysis summary (messaging, cues, social tone, gaps)
- Trend implications for Saxbys' positioning, messaging, and creative direction
- Actionable recommendations for campaign strategy, messaging, and creative development

Timeline

Key Milestone	Start Date	End Date
Research proposal draft	19th Feb 2026	26th Feb 2026
Finalize research proposal	27th Feb 2026	4th Mar 2026
Conduct secondary research	6th Mar 2026	17th Mar 2026
Draft of survey + focus group questions	6th Mar 2026	15th Mar 2026
Finalize survey + focus group questions	17th Mar 2026	20th Mar 2026
Design Qualtrics survey	18th Mar 2026	20th Mar 2026
Launch survey questionnaire	20th Mar 2026	3rd Apr 2026
Recruit students for focus groups	5th Mar 2026	19th Mar 2026
Conduct focus groups	20th Mar 2026	30th Mar 2026
Compile and analyze data and findings	30th Mar 2026	31st Mar 2026
Write research report draft	31st Mar 2026	3rd April 2026
Finalize research report	4th April 2026	10th April 2026

Additional Considerations

- Approval/coordination for on-campus recruitment
- Incentives for focus group participants (gift cards, food, snacks, drinks etc.)